Parshas Behar–Bechukosai

Entering Shalem, Emerging Shalem

Pardes · Shemitah · Eretz Yisrael · Im Bechukosai

I. Something Small That Landed Big

Parshas Behar-Bechukosai is a fascinating parsha to close out Sefer Vayikra with. We have Shemitah, the laws of the land, the brachos and the klalos, and the covenant that wraps everything together. And this year it arrives together with Lag BaOmer, which creates something worth pausing on.

This Lag BaOmer, baruch Hashem, life was busy. Working full time, taking care of the kids, projects stacking up, one thing after the next. My daughter and I made a small medurah together to mark the day, learned some teachings connected to Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, and tried to make it feel meaningful. But then the next day arrived and I was working, running, one client call after another, and about an hour and a half before shkiah I realized: I had not listened to music almost the entire day.

So I put on some Jewish music, let it play in the background while I finished working on a code project. And something shifted. Even though it was not the focused, deliberate kind of listening, just the rhythm, the niggunim, the words of Torah woven into the music playing behind everything else, it lifted me. It gave me energy, a little more pep in the typing. It moved me in a way that I was not expecting. And what struck me afterward was the question that moment raised: what are we letting into our pnimiyus? What are we surrounding ourselves with, absorbing almost without noticing, normalizing? Because eventually, what enters us shapes how we see everything else.

II. Arba Nichnasu LaPardes

That question connects directly to one of the most striking stories in the entire Gemara. The Gemara in Chagigah tells us that four great Tannaim entered Pardes:

עֲקִיבָא וְרַבִּי, אַחֵר, זוֹמָא וּבֶן, עַזַּאי בֶּן ׃הֵן וְאֵלּוּ, לְפַרְדֵּס נִכְנְסוּ אַרְבָּעָה

"Four entered Pardes: Ben Azzai, Ben Zoma, Acher, and Rabbi Akiva."

— Talmud Bavli, Chagigah 14b

Ben Azzai died. Ben Zoma lost himself. Acher became Acher, went off the derech entirely. And Rabbi Akiva, who had warned them all before they went in, entered in peace and emerged in peace. Nichnos b'shalom, yatza b'shalom. All four of them were there. All four saw the same thing. They were each told ahead of time what to expect. So the question that haunts this story is not what they saw. The question is who they were when they saw it.

Among the mefarshim who explore what happened to Acher, there is a detail that stands out. Greek music, Greek culture, the pull of the surrounding world, had been part of his life in a way that was never fully examined or resolved. Things that were perhaps halachically mutar, but still carried an influence, had taken up residence inside him. Externally, Torah. Internally, a competing current. And it was that unresolved tension that he carried with him into Pardes. When he came back down, the cracks gave way. He became Acher. And as a further illustration of just how broken his picture of the world had become, the Gemara tells us that he later witnessed a child perform the mitzvah of shiluach haken, a mitzvah the Torah associates with long life, and the child died immediately afterward. For Acher, already fractured from within, that moment was enough to walk away entirely. The world no longer matched any picture he could hold. What Chazal are showing us is that Acher did not fall because of what he saw. He fell because of what he was already carrying when he saw it.

III. Three More Outcomes, One Generation

It is worth pausing on all three of the failed outcomes, not just Acher, because each one describes something we recognize in the world around us today.

Ben Azzai died. He encountered the divine light and could not survive the encounter. There is something in that image that speaks to the raw, devastating reality of a generation in which Jews are being killed and attacked simply for being here and for being who they are. Not as a punishment and not as an abstraction, but as the outcome of a world that has been stripped of its protective shleimus. When Klal Yisrael is not living in full alignment with its tafkid, the world loses a certain covering. The light that should sustain becomes exposure. Ben Azzai's death is not random. It is the outcome of encountering something holy without the inner vessel to receive it.

Ben Zoma lost his mind. He could not integrate what he saw. He came back down into the world and the world no longer made sense to him. And if we look around honestly, that confusion is everywhere. Adults are confused. Children are confused. Entire generations

are growing up in a reality where the most basic categories of meaning feel scrambled, where the noise is so constant and so disorienting that people genuinely cannot find their footing. It is not that people are wicked or indifferent. It is that something entered, something was absorbed, something was normalized, and now the inner compass no longer points true north. Ben Zoma did not go into Pardes planning to lose himself. He was a great sage. But he was not shalem in the particular way that the encounter required, and the encounter overwhelmed him.

Acher knew. That is perhaps the most painful of the three. He was fully conscious of his choices, fully aware of the tradition he was walking away from, and he walked away anyway. The world did not match his expectations, and rather than questioning his expectations, he rejected the world. There are people today who sit with Torah, who know the halachos, who have real learning, and who look at what is happening around them and arrive at a similar place: maybe it does not actually matter, maybe the promise is not real, maybe the system is broken. That is Acher's despair dressed in modern clothing. And it is devastating precisely because it comes from the inside, from someone who had everything and still could not hold it.

Three people. Three ways of entering something holy without inner alignment. Three outcomes: death, confusion, and conscious departure. The Pardes story is not only about mysticism. It is a map of what happens to a generation that encounters greatness without preparation, and a mirror held up to our own moment.

IV. Rabbi Akiva: Shalem on the Inside

Rabbi Akiva entered the same Pardes and came out whole. And what is striking is where Rabbi Akiva began. He was not born into Torah greatness. He was an am haaretz. He came to learning late in life, building from almost nothing. And yet there was something inside him that was already aligned. The famous image in the Midrash of Rabbi Akiva watching water carve through stone captures it perfectly. If water can do that to stone, Torah can do that to me. That is not a statement of intellect. That is a statement of openness, of honesty, of a person willing to reshape himself around truth rather than reshaping truth around himself. He went into Pardes shalem because he had been tending to his pnimiyus. No foreign current running beneath the surface. No competing voice that had been let in and never resolved.

And it is worth noting: Rabbi Akiva even warned the others before they entered. He told them what to expect. He was already thinking about how the experience would land inside

a person, not just what the experience was. That awareness, that sensitivity to the relationship between what enters a person and what emerges from them, is itself a form of the deepest avodah.

V. Rabbi Shimon Bar Yochai and the Fire

From Rabbi Akiva we reach Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai, his student, and the central figure of Lag BaOmer. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai represents something remarkable in the tradition: Torah so fully internalized that it reshapes not just the person but the space around him. Chazal teach that during his lifetime, a rainbow was not seen in the sky, because his personal merit was already providing the protection that a rainbow signals. The world around him was elevated by who he was inside it.

My daughter and I were sitting by the Lag BaOmer fire and talking about what it actually means. Fire is destructive. It can burn, it can hurt, it can consume. But fire is also Torah. Torah is described throughout our tradition as a fire: halo choh devari ka'esh, is not My word like fire? It is passion directed in the right way, in the right place. We cook with it. We warm ourselves with it. We illuminate with it. The fire of Lag BaOmer is not chaos. It is the image of what happens when a person's inner world is aligned with their outer avodah, when the passion is channeled rather than scattered. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai did not reject the world. He elevated it. After leaving the cave the second time, he could walk through the world and see its beauty rather than its corruption. He could dance with Klal Yisrael. That is the goal: not to hide from the world, but to carry Torah lenses into it, to see through the noise rather than being swallowed by it.

VI. Eretz Yisrael as Pardes

And this brings us directly into Parshas Behar. The parsha opens with Shemitah, and the land of Israel is not passive. It reveals what is already inside the person living on it. The Torah states explicitly:

כִּי לִי הָאָרֶץ

"For the land is Mine."
— Vayikra 25:23

The land does not belong to us. We are guests here with a job to do. And the Torah is clear about what happens when we forget that: the land vomits out its inhabitants. That image

is startling, but it is precise. Eretz Yisrael is not neutral ground. It responds to spiritual alignment. Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai spoke constantly about the beauty of Eretz Yisrael, its necessity, its centrality. Not as geography, but as a spiritual reality. Even for those who are not physically here, mentally, emotionally, your ratzon, your neshama, everything should be oriented toward Eretz Yisrael.

Living here, the parallel is striking. I am not here because I think I am going to change Eretz Yisrael. That is not the orientation. The orientation is: I am here to be changed by Eretz Yisrael, to do my part inside this land, to be metaken myself within it. It is supposed to be a bilateral relationship. And ideally, Eretz Yisrael becomes the Pardes. Rabbi Akiva entered Pardes b'shalom because his ratzon was aligned, because he was not there to impose his own picture onto reality. The Jew who enters Eretz Yisrael properly comes the same way: not to conquer or to perform, but because it is the ratzon Hashem, and because this land is already kadosh and does not need us to make it so.

VII. Shemitah as Inner Alignment

The commentaries on the parsha, across many generations, share a consistent teaching about Shemitah: if a person approaches it properly, with six years of genuine preparation behind him, the produce carries through. The seventh year does not land as a crisis because the work was done in advance. Shemitah, in this reading, is not just an agricultural law. It is a map of inner alignment. What is my kavana in the six years of work? What is my drive? What am I building toward? And then, when the seventh year comes, do I have the inner shleimus to let go, to trust, to stop performing and simply be?

The Torah anticipates the fear:

וְכִי תֹאמְרוּ מַה נֹּאכַל בַּשָּׁנָה הַשְּׁבִיעִת

"And if you will say: what will we eat in the seventh year?"

— Vayikra 25:20

That question is deeply human. And Hashem answers it with a bracha that carries through. But the bracha is contingent on having entered honestly, on having done the work of the six years with the right orientation. Shemitah only works if the years before it were not just about extraction. And perhaps that is the question for all of us, not just those farming in Israel. Are my six days of the week genuinely oriented toward Shabbos? Or is

Shabbos just a recharge so I can go back to work? The Torah is asking about the direction of the whole structure, not just the final day.

VIII. Im Bechukosai Teileichu

From Shemitah, the parsha moves into Bechukosai and the brachos and klalos. And the opening word is worth pausing on:

אִם בְּחֻקֹּתַי תֵּלֵכוּ

"If you walk in My statutes."
— Vayikra 26:3

Not mishpatim, the laws that make logical sense. Not eidus, the laws that preserve memory and historical meaning. Chukim. The laws whose rationale we do not fully grasp. The ones we follow because the Torah says so, and because there is a trust underneath the observance that is itself the avodah. To follow a chok does not mean blind faith in the sense of disconnected compliance. It means I am going to do this, and I am going to feel it, because the relationship with Hashem does not depend on my ability to fully explain it. That is the orientation Rabbi Akiva brought into Pardes. Not I will go in and confirm what I already understand. But I will go in and align myself with what is true even if it is larger than my current picture.

The brachos that follow are abundant: rain in its time, peace, stability, the Shechinah dwelling among us. And then the klalos, which describe exactly what it looks like when alignment breaks down: confusion, fear, exile, a world that feels backwards and chaotic. Reading those klalos, it is hard not to feel their relevance. The klalos are not ancient history. They are a living description of what emerges when an entire generation enters holiness without preparation, when the inner vessel is cracked before the encounter even begins.

IX. Teachers and the Path Back

But that is not where the parsha ends. Because even within the klalos, the Torah builds in the path back. Acknowledgment, teshuvah, return. The structure of Bechukosai is not punishment followed by abandonment. It is consequences followed by a door. And what opens that door is not having everything figured out but being willing to look honestly at where we are.

Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai had Rabbi Akiva. Baruch Hashem, I have my own teachers, and we each get to have teachers along the way. That chain of transmission, from rebbi to talmid, from the light of one generation to the next, is itself how the fire stays alive. It is not about having a perfectly clear understanding of every chok before you act. It is about having enough humility to learn, enough honesty to look at your own pnimiyus, and enough trust to keep walking even when the road is not fully lit.

X. What Lag BaOmer Gave Us

So as we close Sefer Vayikra and come into Shabbos, a few things are worth sitting with. What did I actually receive from Lag BaOmer that I am carrying forward through the rest of the Sefirah? The Sefirah is not over. We are still in the window between Pesach and Matan Torah, still in the structured season of inner preparation. What entered my pnimiyus on Lag BaOmer, whether through fire, through music, through learning, through a conversation, and is that going to carry me through to Shavuos with more alignment than I had before?

The parsha asks us to go into the Shemitah of our week, the Shabbos, with preparation behind it rather than treating it as a reset button. And it asks us to check what is running beneath the surface, what influences have taken up residence inside us that we have not yet examined or resolved. The fire of Rabbi Shimon bar Yochai burns beautifully when it is contained and directed. When it is scattered, it only burns. The choice, as always, is about what we are doing in the six days, in the six years, that makes the seventh the thing it is supposed to be.

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

> • *What am I letting into my pnimiyus right now, not just what I am consciously learning, but what I am absorbing in the background? And how is that shaping the way I see the world?*
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> • *Which of the three Pardes outcomes do I most recognize in myself or around me: the exposure of Ben Azzai, the confusion of Ben Zoma, or the conscious disconnection of Acher? What does that recognition ask of me?*
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> • *Am I living in Eretz Yisrael, physically or in my ratzon and my mind? What does it mean for me to be genuinely oriented toward it rather than just located here?*
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> • *Am I following chukim with trust and feeling, or am I only comfortable with the avodah I can fully explain? Where do I need to stretch into real emunah?*
>
> • *What did I actually receive from Lag BaOmer, and am I carrying it forward through the Sefirah, or has it already faded?*
>
> • *Are my six days genuinely preparing me for Shabbos, or is Shabbos only there to prepare me to go back to work? What would it look like to reverse that orientation?*